
Press, Power, Links and Public Spheres: Newspaper Networks in the Grand Duchy of Finland, 1867–1878

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Abstract

This paper investigates the Finnish-oriented newspaper network of the 1870s as a key infrastructure of national awakening and political enlightenment in the Grand Duchy of Finland. Rather than treating newspapers solely as ideological texts, the study conceptualizes them as interconnected nodes within a broader historical network linking editors, political movements, linguistic publics, censorship authorities, and transnational information flows. Focusing on the period between 1867 and 1878, the paper reconstructs how these press-based networks functioned under conditions of imperial censorship.

The analysis draws on two main categories of historical sources: digitized Finnish- and Swedish-language newspapers and archival records of the Supreme Council of Press Matters (Painoasiain ylihallitus). These sources are inherently fragmented and shaped by censorship practices, administrative intervention, and editorial self-restraint. The paper therefore asks three interrelated questions: how Finnish- and Swedish-language newspapers formed overlapping yet distinct public spheres (Leino-Kaukiainen, 2015; Marjanen, 2019); how imperial censorship shaped, constrained, and at times intensified press networks; and how censored or incomplete sources can be productively mobilized for historical network research (Tommila, 1995).

Methodologically, the study combines qualitative archival reading with relational modeling of newspapers, editors, political affiliations, censored themes, and institutional actors. Banned issues, delayed publications, and confiscations are interpreted not as gaps, but as relational traces that reveal power dynamics and communication pathways. The findings show that Finnish-language Fennoman newspapers—especially *Uusi Suometar* and *Morgonbladet*—as well as other Liberal newspapers such as *Helsingfors Dagblad* functioned as highly connected hubs within an expanding nationalist network and were consequently subjected to disproportionate censorship. Swedish-language liberal newspapers, while facing fewer formal penalties, retained structural importance within urban and transnational circuits (Hyvämäki, 1964; Tuomela, 1958).

The paper argues that censorship itself operated as a network-producing mechanism, generating feedback loops between editors, authorities, and readers, and reinforcing political solidarities across linguistic boundaries. By foregrounding newspapers and censorship records as both sources and network components, the study contributes to methodological debates on abstraction, source bias, and the heuristic value of network thinking in media and political history.

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